

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

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The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

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The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
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ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

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echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

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These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

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experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

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You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day

*What is more valuable than
\$100 million in cold hard cash?*

Many fantasize about winning a fortune, envisioning a life of endless leisure on sun-drenched beaches as the epitome of success. Yet the following stories shatter this myth, revealing a deeper truth about success and the meaning of work.

From the Edge of Suicide to Revolutionary Inventor

At thirty-two, Buckminster Fuller stood on the edge of Lake Michigan one night and spent a few hours contemplating whether he should end his life. After multiple business failures, he felt he had made a mess of his life. He had a substantial life insurance policy, so he thought that it would be best to remove himself to simplify things for his wife and infant daughter.

However, for reasons that we do not know, instead of ending his life, Fuller decided to do something different. He decided to begin a new life as if he had died that night. Being dead, he wouldn't have to worry about himself and would be free to focus his energy on living as a representative

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of the universe. The rest of his life would be a gift. Instead of living for himself, he would devote himself to asking this question:

What is it on this planet that needs doing, that I know something about, that probably won't happen unless I personally take responsibility for it?

He resolved to continuously ask that question and do what came to him.

Buckminster Fuller went from the verge of suicide to inventing the geodesic dome, an entirely new type of architectural structure that is widely used today. This was just one of the twenty-eight patents he was granted. Most people would be thrilled if they could impact one field, but Buckminster Fuller was a true polymath who influenced architecture, engineering, and environmentalism.

Fuller's wisdom heavily influenced my decision to write this book. In the corporate world, I was stunned by how many people mindlessly worked jobs that they found meaningless. When I searched for books on this topic, most fixated on "building your résumé" and "getting a promotion." I discovered that the vast personal development industry pays only cursory attention to the process of choosing your work. I hope this book inspires more educators and companies to bring this critical conversation to their communities.

Buckminster Fuller proves that even a life of despair can be reclaimed to transform an industry. But what happens when the stakes are even higher — when someone else's life is literally in your own hands?

A Matter of Life or Death

James Doty, a neurosurgeon, once operated on a four-year-old child with a malignant brain tumor. The surgery wasn't going well. As Doty describes:

This boy is bleeding to death on the table in front of me... I see the fear in the eyes of the anesthesiologist and we both know that we are running out of time.

Doty calmed his mind, relaxed his body, and visualized a solution. He stated:

I reach in blindly but knowing that each of us is capable of doing amazing things far beyond what we think is possible. I do not accept that this four-year-old is destined to die today on the operating table. I reach down into the pool of blood with the open clip, close it, and slowly pull my hand away. The bleeding stops, and then, as if far away, I hear the slow blip of the heart monitor.

Doty could not accept that a four-year-old had to die on his operating table. He used his body, mind, and intuition to perform this heroic feat. In these moments, when an unexpected difficulty tests our skills to their limits, we find an untapped reservoir of potential within ourselves. This highlights the value of pursuing work that not only plays to your strengths but also challenges you to rise to your full potential. This elite level of performance is unlikely to arise if you do not feel the greater significance of your work.

Doty didn't save that child because he dreamed of an easy retirement. He did it because the gravity of his work pushed the limits of his focus, skill, and intuition. No lottery win can buy the depth or meaning found in this type of work.

This stirring example begs the question: Are you merely laboring on an immediate task before you, or are you working toward something far more meaningful?

How to Build Your Own Cathedral

Zookeepers don't think of their work as just a job. They often describe it as a calling. Driven by their intense love of animals, they willingly sacrifice pay, comfort, and status for the privilege of improving the well-being of animals under their care. They are content to spend only around 20% of their time one-on-one with the animals. The remaining 80% is dedicated to menial tasks like cleaning enclosures and scrubbing floors.

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Zookeepers gladly accept their menial work because they're not just removing waste, but instead, they're creating a healthy environment for their beloved animals. That's why so few zookeepers ever quit the profession. It's like when two stonecutters in the Middle Ages were asked what they were doing. One said, "I'm cutting stones." The other said, "I'm building a cathedral."

The contrasting approaches of the two stonecutters highlight how there are three types of work: jobs, careers, and callings. A job is something you do primarily to earn money. A career is about building your skills and enhancing your earning potential. A calling is a pursuit that you feel compelled to do, irrespective of the financial gain. Choosing your work is about pursuing your calling. Initially, it may be something you do on the side, but ultimately, you want to be like the zookeepers and the second stonecutter, where your job, career, and calling are all the same thing.

Having seen how stonecutters and zookeepers approach their work, let's now explore how you can break free from emptiness to find meaning in your work.

How to Escape from a Meaningless Existence

Peter Barton was a successful television executive who amassed a considerable fortune during his career. As he approached death, he spoke to author Laurence Shames about writing his life story because he wanted to do something important. Laurence replied, "You've already done a lot of important stuff."

"Have I?" Peter asked. "The business stuff? The television stuff? Look, I'm proud of what I've accomplished. A lot of it was creative. I've made a lot of people financially secure. But was it important?"

The question hung in the air as his regret grew more palpable with each passing second.

Buckminster Fuller, on the other hand, did something important. He pushed boundaries as a polymath, impacting the fields of architecture,

engineering, and environmentalism. James Doty did something important. He saved the life of a four-year-old boy and no doubt many others. Zookeepers do something important. They create a healthy environment for animals they love.

Fuller, Doty, and dedicated zookeepers found delight through an intimate commitment to their craft. By discovering the essence of their pursuits, they illuminated the essence of themselves.

What important work is waiting for you?

As I reflect on writing this book, I recall how I initially planned a project to help my children improve their grades at school. But I realized that even if they got top grades, that would offer little solace if their lives were plagued by aimless work they were never meant to do. Instead of reinforcing the status quo, I wanted them to think independently and choose work stemming from their true selves, not their adapted selves. This shift in perspective meant that writing this book was a deeply personal endeavor, making it as meaningful as it was challenging.

As you decide what's important to you, consider that it's impossible to conclude whether creating the geodesic dome mattered more than caring for animals. Everything has its own shape and character. Equally, nothing has any meaning other than the meaning you assign to it. Choose the work that matters to you. Choose the work that uniquely resonates with your being.

When you choose your work, you abandon a life of quiet misery, a life no different than the Greek mythological tale of Sisyphus. Sisyphus was condemned to eternally push a huge boulder up a steep hill, only for it to roll back down just before he reached the top, forcing him to repeat the task indefinitely.

When you focus on activities you find devoid of meaning, your life is no different than Sisyphus' punishment. It doesn't matter how financially rewarding an activity is. It doesn't matter how much you impress other people. If you persist in doing things that you believe are meaningless, the ensuing negative consequences will catch up with you because willful

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blindness has a finite lifespan. You might be able to mislead others for a while, but at some point, the truth will hit you hard. Now is the time to recognize these pointless activities. Now is the time to write them down and come up with a plan to move forward. It's time to choose your work.

Why then do vast amounts of money so often cloud the ability to see clearly?



Figure 4: A life devoid of meaning is like Sisyphus' punishment, endlessly pushing a boulder up a hill, only for it to roll back down, forcing him to start over.

View and download this photo in full color at:

ChooseYourWorkBook.com/sisyphus

What Is the True Definition of Wealth?

Ignoring the insights from Sisyphus, we in the West have been sold the dream that winning the lottery would allow us to retire on an island and live a life of infinite leisure. The modern version of this dream is to work a four-hour day or even a four-hour week. It's a clever sleight of

hand that tricks us into believing financial abundance can mask a deep-seated void in well-being.

The reality is that tackling problems that matter is a primal need — contentment is only possible once you have found a challenge that matters to you. It's no different than any other essential need you have. If you do not exercise for a long time, your muscles begin to atrophy. If you receive endless praise, your capacity to improve is diminished. Growth is impossible in the absence of friction. Unbridled positivity invariably produces stagnation. Ignoring what matters to you might not cause immediate discomfort, but the eventual pain is far greater than any temporary difficulty you'd face from pursuing something meaningful.

Many cultures do not suffer from the misguided dream of retiring on an island. In fact, there's no word for "retirement" in some of these cultures, which helps explain why many never retire. They keep doing what they love for as long as their health allows. In Okinawa, Japan, the community embraces this idea, constantly telling each other, "You count; we need you; let's do something of value together." This mindset is summarized by the word *ikigai*, which loosely translates to "a reason for being." The practice of *ikigai* is a key reason Okinawa has one of the world's highest percentages of people living to over a hundred. Imagine doing meaningful work that you love and, as a result, living for more than a hundred years.

Despite clear evidence in Japan, Western culture still uses money as a fundamental benchmark of success. Money is a useful resource that creates comfortable outer experiences. It's not evil; it's useful. It's perfectly reasonable to aspire to it.

But when it comes to distinguishing between true wealth and miserable poverty, money is a misleading measure of wealth. The poorest life is not the life of someone with little money. Once essential needs are met, the poorest life is one in which you clearly know what energizes you, but for some reason, you deny yourself the opportunity to live the life that makes you tremble with possibility.

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Reject the oversimplified versions of success fed to you on social media and define success in your own terms. True wealth cannot accurately be represented by numbers. It is found in doing things purely because they are worth doing. True wealth is the experience of choosing your work.

What happens if you do not choose your work and solely focus on financial gain? The Ford Motor Company provides a chilling example.

The Unthinkable Memo

In 1973, Ford created the Pinto, only to realize that its fuel tank design posed a severe risk of explosion in rear-end collisions. Instead of recalling the cars immediately, Ford executives wrote what became known as the infamous “Pinto Memo.” This document coldly compared the cost of paying damages for an expected 180 deaths and 180 injuries — about \$49.5 million — to the \$137 million needed for a recall.

Table 3

BENEFITS AND COSTS RELATING TO FUEL LEAKAGE ASSOCIATED WITH THE
STATIC ROLLOVER TEST PORTION OF FMVSS 208

BENEFITS:

Savings - 180 burn deaths, 180 serious burn injuries, 2100 burned vehicles.

Unit Cost - \$200,000 per death, \$67,000 per injury, \$700 per vehicle.

Total
Benefit - $180 \times (\$200,000) + 180 \times (\$67,000) + 2100 \times (\$700) = \underline{\$49.5 \text{ million.}}$

COSTS:

Sales - 11 million cars, 1.5 million light trucks.

Unit Cost - \$11 per car, \$11 per truck.

Total Cost - $11,000,000 \times (\$11) + 1,500,000 \times (\$11) = \underline{\$137 \text{ million.}}$

Figure 5: An extract from the original Pinto Memo. Ford used this internal memo to justify higher profits at the cost of human life.

For context, in 1973, Ford made a \$1.7 billion profit and felt that a mere profit of \$1,563,000,000 was unacceptable, even if that meant killing an expected 180 human beings and injuring an additional 180 people. Stuningly, the court only required Ford to pay \$3.5 million in punitive damages.

The executives at Ford were probably competent executives who achieved their budgets and accomplished their quarterly goals. They were paid well, and when they traveled, they no doubt would have flown business class and stayed at five-star hotels. Yet, beneath their seemingly respectable appearance, there was a callous emptiness inside.

How can a human being become so disconnected from their work that they prioritize company profits over the sanctity of human life? It is staggering to contemplate how these Ford executives reached this state of dysfunction. Perhaps the greatest lesson is that cold logic can create an amorality nothing short of lethal.

While you may justifiably scoff at the Pinto Memo, it's more challenging to ask, "When I was faced with two opportunities, have I ever used money alone to prioritize one opportunity over the other?" If so, you have made the same error as these Ford executives. While you probably didn't harm others, you likely harmed yourself.

In business, you often hear, "Never leave money on the table." In fact, the opposite is true. You *always* want to leave money on the table. Never make optimizing your financial return your top priority because the cost of doing so is disastrously high. Never enter into a profitable business partnership with someone you don't like. Never work so hard to earn money that it comes at the expense of your health. Never do work that makes you a fortune but leaves you feeling empty and unfulfilled. Be extremely careful before you sign up for any lucrative project that may negatively affect your autonomy, creative expression, or relationships. Money has been sold to us as the ultimate cure to all our problems, but in reality, it is merely a blunt tool useful for facilitating interesting experiences. As soon as you let a financial windfall make you feel more significant, you have missed the point entirely.

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The notion, “I want money so that life is easy,” is true insofar as money is required to cover essential needs. However, once essential needs are covered, this notion becomes flawed not only because money fails to make many other aspects of life easy, but also because ease isn’t what you truly want.

Why Difficulty Is Key to Contentment

Imagine going on a long hike with friends through a lush forest. Along the way, you encounter breathtaking views, sparkling rivers, and stunning landscapes that rejuvenate your spirit. However, the hike is challenging, with steep hills and rocky terrain. You find yourself out of breath and struggling at times, barely managing to keep up with the group. When you reflect on the experience a week later, the moments of exhaustion fade into the background. Instead, you feel immense gratitude for witnessing incredible nature and sharing the adventure with loved ones. The very difficulty of the hike amplifies your sense of accomplishment. It tested you. You got through it and climbed to the apex of the mountain. That is a memory that no one can ever take away from you. It’s a memory you will recall over and over, and each time it will bring you great joy.

The same idea applies when choosing your work. If something is easy, it’s boring. If something is challenging, it’s meaningful because it tests you. Great work arises from dancing with tension, not from avoiding it. You want your work to get more and more challenging so that it pushes you to your full capacity.

Paul Kalanithi, a neurosurgeon diagnosed with terminal lung cancer, decided to continue working despite his illness. One of his professors said, “Shouldn’t you be spending time with your family?” If ever there was a time to justify abandoning work, surely this would be it. But Paul continued his work because he felt it was a sacred part of his identity. The hardship he endured only amplified the significance of his work.

Paul’s story highlights how true wealth isn’t measured by the ability to escape work. True wealth is choosing work that resonates so deeply

with you that it becomes an integral part of your being even when, or perhaps especially when, faced with great challenges.

Think of Paul's connection to his work when people on the sidelines say things to you like, "I'm concerned you'll fail. Why don't you do something safe? Why don't you get a stable job? Why aren't you more realistic?"

The day you settle for being realistic is the day something inside you dies. It's the part of you that strives, explores, grows, and creates. It's your creative vitality — that vibrant energy you bring to your work — that enables you to enrich everything you create with a fragment of your essence. What could matter more than preserving your essence? Trading your creative vitality for stability is a terrible deal, which is precisely why only uninspired people preach its benefits.

So greet challenges the way you greet blooming wildflowers — with warmth and joy. Will there be failures along the way? Of course. On the way to earning twenty-eight patents for his inventions, Buckminster Fuller had many setbacks. Some of his projects failed. But he failed at things that mattered to him. When you fail at something that is meaningless to you, it's difficult to persist because you never even cared about what you were doing. But when you fail at something that matters to you, the failure carries far less sting. It's just an obstacle to overcome. You're playing an infinite game that is meaningful to you. The deeper meaning of it all is what makes the difference.

That's why bringing children into the world is profoundly meaningful, even though being woken up multiple times throughout the night hardly sparks joy. The key distinction lies between the short term and the long term. When something makes you happy, it delivers a short-term sparkle, and that's great. But when something is meaningful, it provides you with the gift of long-term contentment.

An achievement may provide happiness, but only a commitment can deliver fulfillment.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

When you are complimented, be grateful and enjoy the sweet experience. But know that happiness is like sunny weather; it comes and goes. Like the weather, there's very little you can do to keep conditions the same. More valuable than the ephemeral feeling of happiness is contentment — the fundamental understanding that your energy is being used in some constructive way.

So hike the harder route that inspires you. Let go of easy but unfulfilling activities. Embrace obstacles as they arise as part of your journey. Choose the work that makes you feel fully alive.

Let's consider what really matters to you in the following reflection.

The Cathedral

1. *What is a problem, gap, or need that matters to me?*
2. *What is one small step I can take tomorrow to make progress in this area?*

Duration

Two minutes

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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- ☐ I have identified a problem, gap, or need that matters to me.
- ☐ I have found one small step I can take tomorrow to move things forward.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

In the Final Chapter...

We'll combine everything we've discussed so the ideas in this book become realities in your life.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

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Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat